PPP wants to have its cake and eat it too. Insiders say the PPP has asked the PML-N for the presidency, all four provincial governorships, as well as the slots of the Speaker of the National Assembly and the Senate chairman in return for its support. Interestingly, not only will it probably mean a return to the presidency of Asif Ali Zardari, these are also constitutional offices that will continue to exist even in the event of any early dissolution of the assemblies.

Bilawal publicly endorsed the possibility of Zardari becoming president again in a press conference on February 13, saying, "I am not saying this because he is my father, but because a fire is raging in Pakistan and only he has the capability to put it out." This may be the smartest strategy for the PPP given the circumstances, and Bilawal may be looking to the future to consolidate the gains the PPP has made in these elections. For one, it swept the province of Sindh (except in Karachi) and became once again the only party with representation in all four provinces. It also became the joint largest party (along with Maulana Fazlur Rehman's Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam or JUI-F) in Balochistan and is looking to form a government in both Sindh and Balochistan. It also improved on its tally at the federal level. But it will need to work hard to recover the ground it has lost in Punjab since the 1990s. Punjab, with more than 50 per cent of the electorate, is the real prize. However, as the youngest of the mainstream leaders, 35-year-old Bilawal has time on his side.

The PPP's reluctance to join the govt stems from the realisation that it's a crown of thorns. Being young, Bilawal also has age on his side

IMRAN'S LONG SHADOW

What few have quibbles with is the fact that, against all expectations, the PTI managed to do what no other party before it had ever managed in the face of a State onslaught. Not only did it manage to use technology to circumvent the electoral hurdles placed before it—getting information out to its voters about which candidate to vote for in each constituency even without a uniform electoral symbol—it was also able to dupe the intel officers whose job it was to keep an eye on PTI mobilisation. The results have certainly given Imran a shot in the arm, convicted as he was in three separate cases for 10, 14 and seven years, just a week before the election. Of these cases, the first two pertain to his having misdeclared

NATION'S NEWEST ARBITER

Pakistan army chief Asim Munir is resolved to see democracy prosper in Pakistan. His challenge is to remain politically neutral while retaining the military's role as the saviour of the country

The single most powerful person in Pakistan is usually the army chief and the current holder of that position is Gen. Asim Munir, who took over the reins of the Pakistan army on November 29, 2022, amid some controversy, even though he was the seniormost lieutenant general at the time.

Selected by then prime minister Shehbaz Sharif to succeed Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa, who had served out two three-year terms after receiving an extension, it turned out that former premier Imran Khan was not in favour of Gen. Munir's appointment. Although the de facto PTI supremo denied this publicly, later events seemed to confirm the initial rumours.

There were a couple of reasons for Imran's apparent antipathy to Gen. Munir. For one, his appointment had immediately cancelled out any future for Imran's favoured candidate, Gen. Faiz Hameed, who had less than a year to go for retirement. Gen. Faiz has been accused of being the strong arm for Imran, helping pressure politicians to join the PTI before the 2018 election and also handling political issues for the party during Imran's time in office.

But perhaps the greatest indicator that there was tension between Gen. Munir and Imran was that the former had been summarily removed as Director General of